The Thirst Department Game

Model how salt pulls water out of cells, how the Thirst Department rings the bell — and why nobody hears it when attention is somewhere else.

Ages 6–9 · 20–25 min · Book link: Chapter 6 and Lab Notes, pages 42–44

YOU NEED

20 paper salt squares (printable), three spots labeled BLOOD, CELLS and WATER CUPS, role cards, two paper flags, a bell if you have one. Signs, role cards and salt squares are on the next pages.

HOW TO PLAY

1. Hand out roles: Popcorn Hand, Thirst Department, Attention, Prince, Maya, two Signals with paper flags (DRY MOUTH and TIGHT-HAT HEAD), three or four Drink players at WATER CUPS — and everyone else is Water, holding hands in a circle in CELLS: a full cell.
2. The body's two rules. One SALT in, one WATER out: each time a salt square lands in BLOOD, one Water player lets go of the circle and walks to BLOOD. One drink in, one WATER home: each Drink player who reaches BLOOD sends one Water player back to the circle.
3. Round 1 — the bottomless bucket. Popcorn Hand drops a salt square into BLOOD every five seconds. The Thirst Department rings each time the cell shrinks, and the Signals wave. Attention keeps copying the Prince. Stop when the cell is down to three.
4. Lights up. Maya asks Attention, "You okay?" Attention turns around and tells everyone what the Signals were saying. Then the drink: Drink players walk to BLOOD one at a time. Watch the cell grow back.
5. Round 2 — picking up the phone. Full cell again, same number of salt squares. This time, whenever a Signal waves, Attention may turn and say "I hear you!" — and one Drink player walks in. Is the cell bigger at the end?
6. Round 3 — a quiet bell. The Thirst Department whispers instead of ringing. Attention closes their eyes and listens. Can they catch it? Swap roles and play again.
7. Talk: which round kept the cell fullest? In Round 1, was the bell quiet — or was nobody listening? What did Attention need?

For the grown-up

It's a model, so it simplifies. Salt doesn't pull exactly one water for each salt, and water leaves cells all over the body at once, a little from each. The real Thirst Department senses the salt-to-water mix — nobody counts. The game leaves out the kidneys, which hold on to water and, over the next hours, send the extra salt out. Jiwoo got a headache too, but a headache isn't part of the thirst bell — many thirsty people never get one. And many children feel nothing on a day like Jiwoo's (page 74). If a player follows a salt or fluid plan from their doctor, let them choose their role; never ask them to explain it.

Nobody turned the bell off. The bell was loud. — L.

Who's who at the movies

POPCORN HAND

JIWOO'S HAND, ON AUTOPILOT

Hold all the SALT squares. Every five seconds, drop one into BLOOD. Don't watch your hand — it keeps moving on its own.

THIRST DEPARTMENT

A TINY OFFICE IN THE BRAIN

Watch the cell. Each time a Water player leaves it, ring the bell — DING! Keep ringing whether anyone is listening or not.

WATER

EVERYONE ELSE, IN CELLS

Hold hands in a circle — a full cell. One SALT in: one of you walks to BLOOD. One drink in: one walks home.

DRINK

WAITING AT WATER CUPS

Stand at WATER CUPS. When Maya waves you in — or Attention says "I hear you!" — walk to BLOOD, one at a time.

ATTENTION

JIWOO'S NOTICING POWER

Face the Prince and copy every move. You only get one attention. Turn around only when the round says you may.

PRINCE

THE MOVIE

Climb an invisible tower very, very slowly. Rest. Wave. Climb again. Your job: keep Attention watching you.

SIGNALS

DRY MOUTH + TIGHT-HAT HEAD

Two players, one flag each. When the bell rings, wave your flag high, where Attention could see it — if Attention looked. No touching. No talking.

MAYA

ASKS THE RIGHT QUESTION

Sit by Attention. When the grown-up calls LIGHTS UP, ask, "You okay?" Then wave the Drink players in.

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Signs for the three spots

BLOOD

CELLS

WATER CUPS

20 SALT SQUARES

